On shifting consumption patterns

The post-COVID era has driven a distinct macro-behavioural shift in the market, punctuated by a sharp increase in multi-generational gatherings and women-centric consumption occasions. Concurrently, the retail infrastructure has undergone a deliberate evolution, transitioning from a purely transactional environment into a more experiential landscape. And, this is evident not just in Delhi and Mumbai, but in regional hubs such as Hyderabad and Goa as well. The domestic retail environment has now evolved to rival international airport duty-free standards; a shift that is characterised by an unprecedented level of sophistication, moving beyond basic product availability to embrace premium consumer experiences, such as bespoke gifting and high-end presentation services.

The new consumer demographic

Further, the Indian market has evolved from a historically dominant whisky landscape into a highly diversified ecosystem, driven by a broader, more dynamic consumer demographic. This has resulted in a rapid portfolio expansion across new brands and categories, which includes the emergence of niche beverage trends, such as the recent rise of the Picante cocktail profile.

The new market opportunities unlocked in a post-COVID landscape has effectively compressed a generation's worth of consumer evolution into a highly accelerated time frame. This growth has been driven by a powerful convergence of market innovation and premiumisation. We at Pernod Ricard have developed domestic innovations, specifically tailored to local consumer preferences, such as the successful launch of Xclamat!on in India (like your showcase of Xclamat!on in Spice). Pernod Ricard's three-pronged innovation strategy includes: India for India; India to the World; Global innovations brought to India.

Pernod's partnership with lifestyle brands

Our global partnership with Scuderia Ferrari reflects a broader strategic imperative to seamlessly integrate with consumer culture and authentic lifestyle passion points. Instead of relying on traditional corporate sponsorship, we aim to establish a distinct, value-driven viewpoint that actively contributes to community conversations and fosters genuine consumer "tribes." While, not every brand operates on this global scale, we apply this same cultural integration strategy at the regional level. For instance, Ballantine's leverages its core brand identity to engage deeply with the music ecosystem. Instead of merely sponsoring large-scale festivals, we partner with major music festivals to drive high-volume brand visibility and broaden consumer reach. We also host parallel, intimate, unplugged sessions with the same headlining artists.

This dual approach showcases the artist in an authentic, premium context, reinforcing the brand's core values, all the while deepening consumer loyalty through these exclusive brand experiences.

Our partnership with designer Gaurav Gupta is a great example of our ability to elevate regional cultural moments into scalable global campaigns. It was developed as a cross-border initiative rather than a localised project, which targeted both the domestic Indian market and the international Global Travel Retail. The strategic objective was focussed on leveraging a unified, premium narrative to celebrate Diwali on a global scale by merging high-fashion brand equity with a major cultural milestone.

The future and innovations

Our product strategy relies on sustainable, scalable commercial traction rather than simply creating a short-term market buzz. Over the next 12 to 18 months, our roadmap focusses on expanding high-potential portfolios, sealing category gaps, and scaling existing core lines across Blenders Pride, Jameson, Chivas, and expanding our Tequila footprint. We plan to scale core extensions around Blenders Pride and Chivas, as also build long-term volume and market depth for established successes such as the Blenders Pride Reserve Collection, Four Elements, and the Zenith Black Edition. As for Jameson, we are driving momentum in the premium Irish whiskey category by introducing targeted portfolio variants such as Jameson Black Barrel and Jameson Triple Triple. We are planning high-growth Innovation Launches (Jameson). In terms of tequila, we are planning to launch Olmeca Altos, while simultaneously scaling Código 1530 to capture the ultra-premium luxury market.

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Trends that coalesce around consumer emotion

It's interesting to note that now it is Bangalore and Goa, and not Delhi or Mumbai that are shaping trends. I find a lot of secret bars, or speakeasies, which are trending because everyday experiences have become too common and accessible. Consumers are searching for something fresh, exclusive, and exciting. The true appeal lies not just in the drink per se, but the unique experience of having access to a hidden place that most people do not know about. These hidden, tiny venues offer a highly curated experience. Without a social media presence, they can be hard to find. It's a very intimate setting where you sit at the bar, interact directly with the bartenders, and enjoy customised drinks, much like a traditional Japanese omakase dining experience.